hindsight'. But Ratan found himself whipsawed by insinuations that the acquisition was both too costly and hastily concluded.

Ishaat Hussain, one of the two Tata Sons directors who eventually abstained from voting to remove Mistry as the chairman, says, 'Have you heard of any acquisition by anybody where people said it has not been overvalued? In 2008, Corus gave us the highest profit in its history. Then came the global financial crisis. Even today, steel consumption in the UK is 30 per cent lower (than at the peak); that's business.' N.P. Sinha, former vice president of Tata Steel, says, 'Look, when you take over management, you should not criticize the past management. That is a given, you have to move ahead. There is no room for "should not have been". This he [Mistry] was doing and showing his small mindedness.'

Hussain elaborates that Tata Steel was not growing in scale and was stuck at an output of 3 million tonnes; many of its greenfield projects had run into local problems too. On the other hand, Lakshmi Mittal acquired Arcelor in 2006, making it a 100-million-tonne producer of steel. He says, 'If you had to be in steel, then something had to be done', and that the acquisition of Corus was a collective decision.

The economic crash of 2008 was a 'black swan' event. 'Steel prices were on an upward trend after 2004 and worldwide demand for steel continued to increase until the global economic crisis emerged,' Hussain elaborates. 'I'm convinced that we did the right thing. In the long-term, it is the right decision. But we have to fix it. For entrepreneurs, opportunity comes once in a lifetime. Cometh the hour, cometh the man and Ratan was the man,' he says dramatically. Ratan gave a 'strategic direction' to Tata Steel during his tenure. Corrective action has to be taken and 'consolidation and restructuring are part of any large acquisition', he adds. Venu Srinivasan adds that instead of solving issues, Mistry was 'constantly harping on the hotspots as he called' them when for four and half years he was at the apex. He 'should have put those hotspots' right and that's why 'he was the chairman and managing director'.

Muthuraman says that if it were not for the economic meltdown, everybody would have praised Ratan and the others involved in the acquisition. Chandrasekaran adds, 'It was because of his vision that Mr Tata created multiple pillars or platforms for the group. Do not look at it in mere P&L terms. We have to build on the platforms, and that is the work to be done.'